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Consumer Autonomy and Social Technology: The Case of Social Media Algorithms and the Metaverse

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ABSTRACT

Consumer autonomy is a central concept in marketing ethics: it is a pre-condition of informed decision making and, as such, a crucial principle which marketers must respect, safeguard and perhaps even promote. Traditional debate on consumer autonomy has focused on the extent to which persuasive advertising undermines the conditions of autonomous choice. Recently, technological advances as well as insights into the biological underpinnings of human choice and self-control have reignited interest into consumer autonomy. This article discusses the impact of social technology (particularly social media algorithms and the metaverse) on consumer autonomy. Based on a tripartite definition of autonomy, we demonstrate how social technology may have a positive impact on autonomy in general, but poses real challenges to one specific type of autonomy. We then discuss two contemporary problems – perceived versus actual autonomy, and genetic causation of consumer behaviour – and use the tripartite definition to explain why these apparent threats to consumer autonomy may not undermine autonomy after all.

Keywords: Autonomy; Ethics; Consumer choice; Technology; Social media; Algorithms; Metaverse

INTRODUCTION

Consumers are often said to be autonomous insofar as they are capable of reflecting critically on relevant information in the marketplace, determining what they have good reason to do, and then acting accordingly (Anker 2020; Wertenbroch et al. 2020). As such, consumer autonomy is the ability to choose between different options in the marketplace. At a philosophical level, consumer autonomy is a foundational principle in liberal democracy and capitalistic market economies because marketers are granted licence to operate to the extent that they respect the consumer's need to make decisions based on what they have good reason to do, in the face of persuasive marketing methods.

The rapid technologization of consumer products and services – and, indeed, of the marketing tools and methods deployed to promote them – has rekindled academic, professional, and regulatory interest in consumer autonomy: debate about the nature and definition of consumer autonomy, why it is worth having, what it means to respect or undermine it, and what role it plays in contemporary consumption is very much at the forefront of marketing

ethics (André et al. 2018; Anker 2020; Daviet, Nave and Wind 2022; Gill 2020; Novak 2020; Wertenbroch et al. 2020; Zheng and Alba 2021).

The aim of this article is to identify, explain and respond constructively to a set of substantive ethical challenges to consumer autonomy posed by marketers' deployment of contemporary and emerging technologies. The article is structured as follows. First, we briefly review the literature on consumer autonomy and formulate three different concepts of autonomy. Second, we identify a set of challenges that social technology – in this case social media and the metaverse – pose to consumer autonomy, and then discuss the extent to which these technologies have a negative, positive or neutral effect on each of the three concepts of consumer autonomy. Finally, we discuss the implications of our tripartite definition of consumer autonomy and demonstrate how it can solve issues relating to conflicts between perceived and actual autonomy, and biological causation of consumer agency.

LITERATURE REVIEW

As Anker (2020) argues, consumer autonomy is a foundational ethical principle in capitalistic market economies that provides marketers with a societal license to operate: Firms' use of their asymmetrical powerbase to deploy marketing methods and technologies to influence consumers to accept marketing offerings is ethically acceptable insofar as there is a certain level of respect for consumer autonomy (e.g. integrity, wellbeing, and the capacity to make informed decisions based on relevant information). It is therefore not surprising that marketing ethics has a long history of discussing autonomy. The existing literature can be divided into three different themes: conceptual studies about the connection between marketing and personal autonomy; critical marketing studies of consumer autonomy as a political construct in capitalistic market economy and consumer society; topical explorations, particularly of the connections between consumer autonomy and new technology.

Marketing and Personal Autonomy

Crisp (1987) stimulated early debate on the topic through his seminal paper 'Persuasive advertising, autonomy, and the creation of desire', arguing that persuasive advertising is often at odds with autonomy. The crux of the argument is that persuasive advertising can induce and autonomy which argues that marketing methods can induce subconscious desires that consumers are unable to reflect on. When consumers are influenced to act on such advertising-induced desires, their cognitive capacity to reflect on and evaluate their own desires is curtailed, which hinders informed decision making and thereby autonomous agency. Barrett (2000), Raley (2006) and Sneddon (2001) have elaborated on Crisp's account to clarify how advertising can bypass consumers' ability for critical reflection. Contrary to this, Arrington (1982) and Cunningham (2003) have argued for a balanced position whereby some persuasive advertising is often compatible with consumer autonomy. These early contributions to the scholarly debate disagreed over the extent to which persuasive advertising would undermine consumer autonomy, but they all shared the same underpinning assumption: there is no positive correlation between marketing and consumer autonomy.

Responding to this, Anker, Kappel and Sandøe (2010) have explore how marketing may have a positive impact on the enabling conditions of autonomy, for example by empowering consumers to act on motivations that are of high importance to them, but which they have been unable to act on without external support, motivation and influence (e.g. eating healthier, domestic recycling, engaging in physical exercise). Recently, the debate has taken a new turn. Inspired by the biological sciences, new studies argue that consumer autonomy may be highly limited because genetic pre-dispositions significantly moderate – sometimes

perhaps even cause – consumers' behavioural patterns (Daviet, Nave and Wind 2022; Zheng and Alba and 2021).

Critical Marketing and Consumer Autonomy

Critical marketing scholars are not so much concerned with the nature of consumer autonomy, but focus more on its political role in consumer society. The notion of 'autonomy' is often seen as an illusion that is being used to legitimise commercial corporations' exploitation of their asymmetrical powerbase to influence consumers to buy products and services for which they do not have any genuine need or desire (Arnould 2007; Baudrillard 1998; Kozinets 2002). Seen through the lens of social systems theory, consumer autonomy is a concept that the capitalistic market system uses to justify consumerism as a foundational pillar of society. As Tadajewski (2019) notes, consumers think of their consumption habits as their own freely chosen patterns of behaviour while, in reality, their actual autonomy is undermined by economic market-forces that sub-consciously induce desires and preferences for new products and brands.

Consumer Autonomy and Marketing Technology

Maturing technologies such as social media provide opportunities and threats to consumer autonomy. For example, research on consumer empowerment has found that social media and peer-to-peer platforms offer tangible enhancement of consumer empowerment (Labrecque et al. 2015; 2013). Consumers can seamlessly communicate and engage with other consumers across the globe, thereby obtaining reach and influence on other consumers, brands and businesses that would have been impossible without internet-based social technology. Technologically enhanced consumer empowerment and autonomy has also been demonstrated to enable consumers' ability to initiate social change through self-organization and mobilization (e.g. Greta Thunberg and the School Strike for Climate movement; consumer-to-consumer emergency projects during Covid-19 lockdowns to supply sick, elderly and shielding consumers with essential supplies). On the flipside, it has been argued that algorithmic curation of content on social media reinforces consumers' existing beliefs, assumptions and desires and, thereby, promotes a groupthink and reinforces self-identity confirmation biases. The lack of diverse and dissonant content from consumers' social media profiles creates a cognitive environment that threatens to undermine autonomy by depriving users from expose to alternate reference points that are necessary for critical reflection and informed decision-making.

André et al. (2018) have explored the connection between autonomous technologies in consumer products and consumer autonomy. Central to this discussion is the notion of consumer responsibility: when are consumers responsible for accidents with autonomous consumer products such as self-driving cars, robotic lawnmowers, and smart homes where proprietary, AI-based technology operates the products (Gill, 2020; Novak, 2020)?

Finally, the biological sciences are increasingly impacting on consumer technologies, products and services (Daviet, Nave and Wind 2022; Zheng and Alba 2021). For example, firms such as 23andMe offer consumer DNA testing kits and associated genetic reports on individual ancestry and family history. Such products pose new types of challenges to consumer autonomy, because consumers may consent to commercial use of their personal data without being able to fully realising the potential, adverse consequences (Daviet, Nave and Wind 2022). This raises the question whether voluntary consent is sufficient to safeguard autonomy with respect to products that may lead to substantive, negative, future outcomes that consumers cannot reasonably foresee at the time of giving their consent. In the case of 23andMe, the firm has sold access to their consumer DNA database to GlaxoSmithKline for $300 million, thus putting consumer data at the heart of commercial utilisation that many consumers would not have been able to foresee at the time of giving their consent.

THREE CONCEPTS OF AUTONOMY

It is possible to distinguish between three different concepts of autonomy. First is the mainstream understanding of consumer autonomy that defines the concepts by reference to notions of freedom: consumers are free to the extent that they can make choices that are not determined by internal or external influences. This kind of autonomy comes in different degrees: full autonomy understood as a consumer being completely free from internal and external influence is what Kant would call 'a regulative ideal': something that we can aspire without ever being able to fully realise. In practice, consumers always already face a range of constraints and influences such as existing desires, preferences, etc. as well as contextual influences from peer-groups and, indeed, advertising, branding and other marketing methods. This is the type of autonomy that informs much of the contemporary debate in marketing, including scholars arguing for the value and importance of consumer autonomy (Wertenbroch et al. 2020) and scholars seriously curtailing the role of consumer autonomy based on an understanding of the biological causation of human choice (Zheng and Alba 2021).

Second, the philosophical literature on autonomy also identifies another version of the concept: autonomy as a form of authenticity defined as the ability to act on desires and preferences that are reflective of one's stable desires, personal values and worldview (Buss and Westlund 2018). Contrary to the mainstream understanding, this concept of autonomy is not defined with reference to ideas about consumer freedom and the ability to make voluntary choices in the marketplace. Rather, this is an idea of autonomy that has developed from the branch of philosophy called 'compatibilism', which is the view that moral responsibility is compatible with determinism (i.e. a world in which all events, including human actions, are a necessary outcome of causal laws or chains of events). In philosophy, the debate is often polarized and offering mainly binary options between either indeterminism (i.e. the mainstream concept of autonomy and free will) or determinism (i.e. moral responsibility without the ability to act otherwise).

Finally, the third idea of autonomy shifts focus away from individuals' ability to make choices or to act in ways that are conducive to existing values and preferences. It has less to do with agency and more to do with reflexivity and the notion of being a self. This is the idea of autonomy as personhood. This view holds that in order for someone to be an autonomous person or consumer, then they need to demonstrate critical reflexivity with respect to their own subjective experiences. In the essay 'The Dialogical Self', Taylor (1995) describes the relevant process of critical reflexivity as follows: "To be interested in my own health or wealth is to be reflexively oriented, but not radically. But when I examine my own experience, or scrutinize my own thinking, reflexivity takes a radical turn." The third concept of autonomy thereby requires the individual consumer not only – and perhaps not primarily – to make informed decisions or act in accordance with their own best interests: rather, it requires the consumer to be a certain type of person. That is, to be an autonomous consumer it is necessary to reflect critically on one's own experience as a consumer. This involves scrutiny of one's own desires, preferences, values and choices as a consumer.

In applied contexts such as marketing ethics, there is a history of consensus on synthesizing different philosophical views and moral positions into unified frameworks that can explain the varied nature of consumer agency. A prominent example if Hunt and Vitell's (1986) general theory of marketing ethics, which combines a range of philosophical positions – ranging from deontology to utilitarianism and communitarianism – into a unified framework of ethics. In philosophy, these positions are mostly thought of as competing views. In marketing, however, we tend to accept some degree of conceptual conflict between different

theories if a synthesis offers tangible, applied benefits in terms of informing consumer decision making, campaign development, marketing regulation, etc. Based on this tacit, pragmatic agreement (which is closely aligned with Peirce's idea of ethics and truth), we suggest that all three concepts of autonomy are important in marketing ethics. As such, in the following critical discussion of ethical challenges to consumer autonomy posed by marketing technology, we draw on all three concepts of autonomy in our evaluation of the risks and benefits posed by the various technologies. We have formulated the three concepts of autonomy into the following propositions:

> *Autonomy as freedom of choice* – A consumer is autonomous insofar as they can choose freely between a set of products or services in the marketplace.
>
> *Autonomy as authenticity* – A consumer is autonomous insofar as they can choose marketing offerings that reflect their stable desires, preferences and values.
>
> *Autonomy as personhood* – A consumer is autonomous insofar as they reflect critically on their own subjective consumer experience.

SOCIAL TECHNOLOGY AND CONSUMER AUTONOMY

The rapid development of social technologies, particularly the ubiquitous penetration of social media, has transformed what it means to be and act as a consumer. And emerging social technologies such as the metaverse may offer new revolutions in consumer behaviour of the same importance and magnitude. Here, we discuss the relationship between both social media and the metaverse on consumer autonomy.

Social Media and Consumer Autonomy

We understand social media as internet-based platforms such as TikTok, YouTube, FaceBook, Twitter, Weibo, LinkedIn, etc. which form virtual networks that allow users to share content (text, audio, visuals and videos) and engage through text- or video-based communications in real-time across the world. One prominent feature of social media technology is the development and deployment of AI-based algorithms that influence the type of content consumers are exposed to. Social media algorithms are designed to recommend content to users based on a range of variables such as past behaviour (e.g. type and quantity of content consumed, likes, shares, posts), demographics, time spent on various online activities, followers, etc.). The obvious benefit is that social media consumers are being exposed to content that is relevant and personalised, as opposed to a random selection of content in one's social media feeds based on, say, the chronological order of publication.

We will now analyse the relationship between the use of predictive algorithms to select relevant content for individual social media users and consumer autonomy. First, in terms of autonomy as freedom of choice, the impact of predictive algorithms is limited. While algorithms present consumers with content that is more relevant in terms of being tailored to their interests, they do not obviously extend the size of consumers' overall choice-set. The set of *relevant* choices is increased, but the total set of choices is not altered: if consumers where fed all content chronologically or randomly, they would still have access to the same content and choice of products or services, it would just be harder and more laborious to search for the best options.

However, the use of algorithms to personalise social media content has significant impact on autonomy as authenticity. We defined this type of autonomy as consumers' ability to

choose marketing offerings that reflect their stable desires, preferences and values. Predictive algorithms are enabling just that: serving consumers content – such as reviews, advertisements, products and services – based on past behaviours and other variables that are informative of consumers' desires, preferences and values as they are continuously enacted over time (and in that sense time-stable). But there is also a dark side to personalisation. Consumers may use social media to explore personal desires that conflict with their personal values or that are in other ways harmful to them. For example, there is growing evidence of how consumers with mental health conditions have consumed harmful content on social media platforms that has worsened their condition (Karim et al. 2020). One case in point is consumption by primarily younger social media users of content about self-harm (Patchin, Hinduja and Meldrum 2022). Young and psychologically vulnerable consumers who explore self-harm on social media are quickly being spun into an online world where algorithms continuously "optimise" the personalisation of their content by feeding them with more and more content of self-harm. This continuous reinforcement normalises the harmful content and influences especially young and vulnerable consumers to see self-harm as an acceptable coping strategy.

Another much-debated outcome of the use of predictive social media algorithms is filter bubbles (Seargeant and Tagg 2019). These occur when predictive algorithms increasingly expose social media users to content (advertisements, reviews, products, opinions, views, news stories, etc.) that confirms and reinforces their existing experience and worldview. As predictive algorithms continuously learn more and more about an individual social media consumer, the type of content being shown in their personal feed increasingly narrows in scope, becoming ever more personalised and targeted to converge on existing desires, beliefs, views and so on. The implication for consumer autonomy as personhood is profound: the continuous reinforcement of consumers' existing beliefs and worldviews is a clear barrier to critical self-reflection on one's subjective experience as a consumer because the consumer is increasingly being deprived from content that could act as trigger points for critical self-reflection. A reflective self requires a fertile environment with exposure to a diverse range and type of content that can be used as external reference points against which one can scrutinize one's own consumer experience (Taylor 1995).

The Metaverse and Consumer Autonomy

The metaverse is a digital space that combines elements of virtual and augmented reality, social media, cryptocurrency and gaming to create an environment where users can interact with each other in multiple different ways. The metaverse allows users to connect, work, learn, play and, of course, shop. Many brands now have a presence in Meta's Metaverse, including global ones like Nike, Adidas, Gucci, Coca-Cola and Wendy's. While these brands, and hundreds of others, have already established their presence in Metaverse, thousands more are likely to follow in the coming years. It is also worth noting that Meta's Metaverse is just one manifestation of an immersive world in the metaverse: many more are likely to be launched. We can think of the metaverse as a digital universe with currently one big planet, Meta's Metaverse. But it is an infinite virtual space that can accommodate infinitely many new worlds. The metaverse already comprise several immersive worlds such as Roblox, Decentraland, Sandbox, Somnium Space, and last but not least Second Life. The latter was the first major pioneer into the metaverse and was released by Linden Lab in 2003, whereas Meta's Metaverse launched in 202.

The metaverse is highly relevant to our discussion of autonomy. It obviously reinforces the mainstream concept of consumer autonomy by enhancing freedom of choice. The pioneering brands in the Metaverse are not only offering an additional channel through which consumers can purchase goods and interact with brands. Many brands are also developing new products such as NFT-based clothing for avatars, sound-visualizers, trading cards and

interactive events. The Metaverse thereby reinforces consumer autonomy as freedom of choice by adding a new domain that enables new types of choices and enhancing the overall choice-set of consumers by offering new products and services that are not available elsewhere in the totality of the marketplace.

The metaverse also holds significant promise for the enhancement of autonomy as authenticity. Obviously, it offers consumers an additional channel that augments the customer journey, but that is not the real potential. Rather, the metaverse comprises immersive worlds that each offer consumers distinct ways of shopping, searching for information about products and services, interacting with brands and engaging with other consumers. These forms of engagement are not just other ways of doing 'physical world' activities, the metaverse offers entirely distinct types of consumer experiences. For example, Roblox is a virtual world that contains more than 50m games that are all produced by its community of users. This is a very significant form of consumer-to-consumer engagement that is unique to this immersive world. Decentraland is another interesting example. This is a metaverse based on landownership facilitated through blockchain technology. Decentraland is made up of individual plots of virtual land that consumers can purchase and then claim ownership in the form of NFT LAND. Breakroom is an example of a newly formed metaverse in response to the Covid-19 pandemic. It provides an immersive world where businesses can collaborate, conduct meetings and conferences. It also offers educators the opportunity to create virtual classrooms.

Looked at holistically, the metaverse thereby provides all consumers with an array of opportunities to enhance autonomy as authenticity by offering distinct ways to enacting their stable desires, preferences and values. For specific consumer groups such as people with disabilities, the benefits of the metaverse include access to interactive education and type of work that otherwise would not have been possible (e.g. estate agents in Decentraland, fashion designers in the Metaverse, professors in business schools, etc.). Finally, metaverse agency is often mediated through avatars that allow consumers to enact identities that may be different from their 'off-line' identity. To many consumers, this is a unique opportunity to enact preferences, desires and interests that they otherwise would or could not have allowed themselves in the off-line word.

It is more challenging to evaluate the impact of the metaverse on autonomy as personhood per se because it depends on the ontology of the specific immersive worlds (e.g. Roblox, Metaverse, Decentraland) in the metaverse. It seems likely that as the metaverse is being populated with new immersive worlds, some of these will comprise features that enhance critical self-reflection (e.g. educational providers in the metaverse), whereas other worlds may be specifically designed for critical self-reflection (imagine, for example, a metaverse dedicated to the discussion of philosophy). Thus, depending on what types of worlds will be created in the metaverse, it may offer substantive opportunities for genuine self-exploration that is consistent with and conducive to the enhancement of autonomy as personhood.

Table 1 summarises the impact of the discussed social technologies on consumer autonomy.

Type of consumer autonomy	**Autonomy as freedom of choice**	**Autonomy as authenticity**	**Autonomy as personhood**
Definition	A consumer is autonomous insofar as they can choose freely between a set of products or services in the marketplace.	A consumer is autonomous insofar as they can choose marketing offerings that reflect their stable desires, preferences and values.	A consumer is autonomous insofar as they reflect critically on their own subjective consumer experience.

Social media (predictive algorithms)	*Neutral* No obvious enhancement of overall freedom of choice.	*Positive* Enable consumer experiences and choice of products/services that are aligned with time-stable desires, preferences and values. *Negative* Enable and reinforce consumption of harmful content.	*Negative* Undermines the enabling conditions of critical self-reflection.
Metaverse	*Positive* Introduction of new types of choices and expansion of overall choice-set available to the consumer (e.g. new products).	*Positive* Introduction of new types of consumer experiences and agency that enables enactment of important desires, preferences and values.	*Neutral* The ontology allows for worlds that may be able to enhance critical self-reflection but at present no strong indication of this being a dominant feature of the technology.

Table 1. Impact of social technology (social media algorithms and the metaverse) on three concepts of consumer autonomy.

DISCUSSION

We will now discuss the contributions of our analysis to the scholarly understanding of consumer autonomy before discussing societal responses and pathways for future research.

Contributions to Research on Consumer Autonomy

A general implication of our analysis is that social technology has a substantive potential to improve the enabling conditions of consumer autonomy across all three types of consumer autonomy (see table 1). This challenges early contributions that focused on the impact of persuasive advertising on consumer autonomy and predominantly found advertising to undermine – or at best be neutral to – consumer autonomy (Arrington 1982; Barrett 2000; Crisp 1987; Cunningham 2003; Raley 2006; Sneddon 2001). We note that Anker, Kappel and Sandøe (2010), in their response to the early critique of consumer autonomy, demonstrated that advertising may have a positive impact on autonomy as freedom of choice.

However, the main reason why scholarly debate has tended to view marketing as a threat to autonomy is probably the adoption of a narrow concept of autonomy as freedom of choice in both early and contemporary research on consumer autonomy. A key contribution of this study is therefore to demonstrate that when a broader understanding of personal autonomy is brought to bear on consumer behaviour, marketing has a more nuanced and often more positive relationship with autonomy. This study thereby extends Anker, Kappel and Sandøe's (2010) project to broaden our understanding of a fertile relationship between marketing and consumer autonomy by analysing how deployment of social technology in marketing can enhance the quality of being an individual person with integrity and authenticity. There is an important caveat though: the negative effect of social media algorithms on personhood calls into question the potential positive impact on authenticity which our analysis is also pointing towards: is it possible for marketing to have a positive impact on the development of consumer authenticity whilst at the same time undermining the enabling conditions

of personhood? This is a conflict that, at least in part, must be addressed through a value-based discussion of which types of autonomy are most important to consumers. This, in turn, is an empirical question which future research could explore through a range of methodological approaches. These explorations could use qualitative studies to understand in-depth what it means for consumers to be autonomous (perceived autonomy), experimental studies to understand the importance of the different types of autonomy in different decision-making scenarios (actual autonomy), and, finally, quantitative surveys to understand the value of autonomy to different consumer segments across large populations (normative autonomy).

Perceived versus Actual Autonomy

Experiential marketing has the potential to enhance a consumer's feeling of empowerment and autonomy without necessarily enhancing their set of possible options to choose from. Wertenbroch et al. (2020) refer to such situations as conflicts between perceived and actual autonomy. They argue that such conflicts are not necessarily ethically problematic because "… perceived autonomy remains resilient in the face of numerous threats (p. 432)". The argument is substantiated through reference to experimental studies that have found that when people are informed that their choices are predictable from their previously measured choices and preferences, participants act with psychological reactance and choose sub-optimal options just to prove their autonomy. By contrast, when participants are informed that their future choices are consistent with their past preferences there is no perceived threat to autonomy and no need to prove one's autonomy through choices that diverge from past preferences and motivations.

We are able to augment this argument and explain it with reference to the different types of autonomy. Wertenbroch et al. (2020) operate with the mainstream concept of autonomy as freedom of choice and therefore have to explain the conflict between perceived and actual autonomy by reference to other psychological theory such as psychological reactance. However, our tripartite definition of autonomy allows us to understand this conflict as a dynamic relationship between different types of autonomy. When consumers feel that their actual autonomy is threatened (autonomy as freedom of choice) they feel a need to ensure whether this is a major challenge to their status as being an autonomous person. By reassuring themselves that being predictable is a matter of acting consistently with their past preferences, they assure themselves that their autonomy as authenticity is intact. As such, when marketing methods pose a threat to consumers' freedom of choice – say, by inducing a desire to purchase a specific product – perceived and actual autonomy is *not* compromised insofar as the induced desire is consistent with the consumer's stable preferences, desires and values. Undermining autonomy as freedom of choice is only an ethical problem insofar as it also undermines one or both other types of autonomy.

Autonomy and the Biological Underpinnings of Choice

Insights into the biological determinants of human choice pose a challenge to traditional understandings of consumer autonomy. Zheng and Alba's (2021) review of biological evidence on self-control "… reveals that biological causation runs counter to deep-seated views of self-control and raises very delicate questions about autonomy (p. 118)". The upshot of their analysis is that consumer autonomy is, at best, very limited and that many – and perhaps most of our important decisions – are significantly informed by and predictable from our inherited genetic dispositions. They conclude my observing that this scientific conclusion is difficult to the average consumer because it runs counter to our deep-rooted beliefs about autonomy and freedom of choice. They also issue a call for marketing scholars to be a catalyst for change by raising awareness of what this means for consumers and suggest solutions for how this new scientific understanding of individual behaviour should be managed.

Again, the tripartite definition of autonomy suggested in this article has much to offer in terms of expanding our understanding of autonomy and clarifying why a threat to autonomy is not necessarily a big ethical issue. As with Wertenbroch et al. (2020), Zheng and Alba (2021) operate with the mainstream concept of autonomy as freedom of choice. In this perspective, autonomy is undoubtedly compromised by the revelation that most of our choices are influenced by our genetic dispositions and, in that sense, not as free as we thought and perhaps would have liked. However, external causation of consumer agency does not necessarily compromise autonomy per se: it is crucial that our actions are aligned with our important preferences and values, but on a tripartite understanding of autonomy it is of less importance how his alignment of choice with our preferences has come about. A consumer who acts based on motivations that have causal origins in their inherited DNA is still autonomous insofar as those motivations are consistent with their stable preferences, desires and values.

CONCLUSION

This article has introduced three concepts of consumer autonomy: autonomy as freedom of choice, autonomy as authenticity, and autonomy as personhood. We have demonstrated how social technology – particularly social media and the metaverse – may impact on each type of autonomy. We found that social technology has a substantial potential to enable and augment autonomy across all three types of autonomy. However, the algorithms used on social media platforms to personalise content can have a severe negative impact on autonomy as personhood because they erode the potential for critical self-reflection in response to diverse content. We concluded the paper with a discussion of challenges to autonomy and demonstrated the explanatory power of the tripartite definition: threats to consumers autonomy as freedom of choice are often not as damaging as scholars suggest because the notion of being an autonomous person with integrity and authenticity is resilient in the face of external influence and causation.

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